The search party picked up the scent of the Barakzais when, after two weeks on the hunt, they caught up with some deserters from Dost Mohammad's bodyguard and learned that they were only one day behind the fugitives. 'At five pm we resumed our march,' wrote an exhausted Lawrence,

> contrary to the protest of the Hadjee, who expressed himself most unwilling to proceed, alleging the dangerous and precipitous character of the road for a march at night.[§] It was quite apparent his heart was not in the cause. His objections were not listened to, and we proceeded by a very bad road, over high hills and along the dry channels of mountain streams, for ten miles, where we halted and lay down by our horses . . . Not fifty of our Affghans reached the ground with us; but they came in during the day. Here we received intelligence that the Dost was at a place called Youk, only one march ahead of us. Hadjee Khan again showed great reluctance to advance, begging Outram to halt there, as the Dost had 2,000 horsemen with him. Outram however ordered the party to march at four pm, and on mustering the Affghans found they numbered only 350, and they badly mounted.[27]

These delaying tactics continued over the days that followed. The Haji insisted that they needed to wait for reinforcements, and when Outram tried nevertheless to set off on a night ride, 'whether through accident or design, we had not advanced four miles, before the guides, who were under the charge of Haji Khan's men, were reported to have deserted. It was then pitch-dark, and being left in the midst of interminable ravines, where no trace even of a footpath existed, we had no alternative but to halt until day break.'[28] The next evening as the British tried to press on, Haji Khan seized Outram by the arm 'and loudly entreated me not to think of advancing, threatening rather to detain me by force, than to permit my rushing on certain destruction'. He also warned him, no doubt truthfully:

> if you do encounter Dost Mohammad, not one of the Afghans will draw a sword against him, nor will I be responsible if they do not turn against yourself in the melee . . . Failing in his object of shaking our resolution, the Khan at last left and seating himself a few yards from the door of my tent, conversed in the dark in an undertone of voice, with three or four of his chiefs for more than an hour. The latter were heard to upbraid him for assisting the Firangis in their endeavours to arrest Dost Mohammad, enquiring whether the Amir had ever injured him . . . and Haji Khan was heard to admit the truth of all they had advanced.[29]

The following day, as snow began to fall, the Afghans of the party turned increasingly mutinous. 'We realized', wrote Outram, 'that our own Afghans were traitors upon whom no reliance could be placed.' Outram and Lawrence then decided to go on a mission that seemed almost suicidal,